From Jobcentre Plus to Jobs and Careers: A New Era for Employment, Skills & Careers Support

Introduction: an opportunity to rethink employment support

For decades, Jobcentre Plus has been a familiar part of the UK's employment support system. Alongside it, the National Careers Service has helped people understand their options, develop their skills and make informed career decisions, with delivery supported by a range of private, specialist and community-sector organisations.

From 1 October 2026, the DWP brought Jobcentre Plus and the National Careers Service together in England through a new Jobs and Careers Service. This is more than a change of name or organisational structure. It creates an opportunity to build a more connected service that helps people find work, make career choices, develop skills, progress in employment and increase their earnings.

The ambition is significant.
Whether it becomes a genuine step change will depend on how well the service translates that ambition into a better experience and better outcomes for individuals, employers and local communities.

One journey, not separate transactions

People rarely experience employment, careers and skills as separate issues. Someone looking for work may also need to understand their transferable skills, identify training, explore a new occupation or work out how to progress once they are employed. Historically, those needs have sometimes required people to navigate different services and systems.

The Jobs and Careers Service has the potential to bring these elements together around the person. Rather than asking people to work out which part of the system they need, the service should help them move between advice, job matching, skills development and practical support as their circumstances change.

That means designing around the whole journey: what someone can do, what they want to do, what employers need, what skills may be missing and what support will help them take the next step.

Digital innovation must strengthen human support

The government's ambition for a service that is digital where possible and human when needed is a useful starting point. Digital tools, data, automation and artificial intelligence can improve access to information, support job matching, make skills more visible and help people explore opportunities at times that suit them. Better labour-market intelligence could also help employers identify candidates whose abilities match their needs.

However, technology should be a means to better outcomes, not an end in itself. For people who are confident, digitally capable and ready to move quickly into work, online services may remove unnecessary barriers and make support more accessible. Others may face homelessness, disability, health conditions, caring responsibilities, low confidence, limited digital access or several barriers at once. In those circumstances, a digital offer alone will not be enough.

People may need trust, continuity, professional judgement and practical help from someone who understands their circumstances. The test is therefore not simply whether the technology works, but whether it enables skilled staff to spend more time supporting people effectively.

Protecting the value of professional careers guidance

Bringing careers support closer to employment services should make it easier for people to access the right advice at the right time. DWP has stated that qualified careers advisers will continue to provide in-depth guidance, particularly for people who face greater barriers to work or learning, including disabled people and young people who are not in education, employment or training.

The face-to-face element of the National Careers Service in England is moving into DWP's careers service, while the existing website continues as a digital careers information and advice resource under the identity 'Get careers information and advice'. This creates an opportunity to connect professional careers guidance more closely with job-search support and skills development.

That opportunity must be matched by a clear recognition of the professional expertise, independence and impartiality of careers advisers. Careers guidance is a specialist discipline, not simply another task within an employment service. Its contribution should be protected and valued within the new model.

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A more intelligent, skills-based approach

A modern employment service should look beyond job titles and previous roles to understand what people can do and what they could learn. Skills are often transferable across sectors, but individuals may need support to recognise and explain them.

Experience in hospitality, for example, may develop communication, organisation, customer service and problem-solving. Unpaid caring can involve planning, responsibility, resilience and complex coordination. Construction work may build technical, practical, teamwork and project-management capabilities. A better understanding of these skills can help people identify opportunities they may not otherwise have considered.

The question should increasingly move from 'What job have you done before?' to 'What can you do, what could you learn, and where could those skills take you?' Used well, skills information can help connect people to vacancies, training and career pathways that reflect both their potential and labour-market demand.

Employers and local labour markets must be central

Employment support cannot focus only on helping individuals become ready for work. It must also understand employer demand and the realities of local economies. Employers need people with the right skills; individuals need access to good-quality, sustainable jobs; and local economies need businesses that can recruit, retain and develop their workforces.

The new service should build relationships with employers that go beyond collecting vacancy details. It should understand current and emerging skills needs, recruitment challenges, growing sectors, entry routes and the changes employers can make to recruit more inclusively. This intelligence should inform careers advice, training choices and job matching.

National consistency is important, but employment opportunities and barriers differ by place. The labour market in Derbyshire will not be identical to that in central London, Manchester, Sheffield or Cornwall. Local transport, housing, health services, skills provision and community support can all affect whether someone can access and sustain employment.

The government's test-and-learn approach, including work with local authorities and combined authorities, offers a route to explore how the service can work more effectively with local partners and employers. The long-term aim should be a service that is nationally coherent but locally informed.

Connect the wider employment and skills ecosystem

The transition should not be seen simply as a transfer of careers advice into DWP. Employment outcomes depend on a wider network that includes local authorities and combined authorities, colleges and training providers, employers, specialist employment providers, voluntary and community organisations, health services, housing and homelessness organisations, and youth services.

The Jobs and Careers Service should help people navigate this ecosystem and strengthen coordination between its parts, rather than attempt to replace them. Some people will need a straightforward digital journey or support from a Work Coach. Others may need specialist employment provision, impartial careers advice or a coordinated package involving health, housing, skills and employment support.

Private, voluntary and community-sector organisations will continue to have an important role. They often bring specialist expertise, trusted relationships and access to communities that statutory services may find harder to reach. Government can provide leadership, infrastructure and core services, while partners contribute their knowledge, innovation and specialist support. This requires genuine collaboration, clear referral pathways and a shared focus on the individual—not organisational boundaries.

Reaching people furthest from the labour market

One of the most important measures of success will be whether the service reaches people who are not already connected to employment support. This includes economically inactive people, disabled people, young people who are NEET, people experiencing homelessness, those managing health conditions, people returning to work after a long absence and individuals who have lost confidence or whose experience does not readily translate into today's labour market.

An ambition to reach people who are not receiving regular Jobcentre Plus support or benefits could be transformative. But people who are distant from the labour market may not find their way to a website or formal service without help. Trusted relationships with local organisations, community networks and specialist providers will be essential to building engagement and helping people take their first steps.

Success should not be judged solely by how efficiently the system supports people who are already close to employment. It should also be judged by

whether it can engage people with more complex needs and provide the sustained, coordinated support that helps them move forward.

Measure what matters: sustainable work and progression

Appointments completed, referrals made, CVs produced and vacancies discussed can all provide useful operational information, but they are not the ultimate purpose of employment support. The focus should be on outcomes that make a lasting difference.

That means looking beyond whether someone starts a job to ask whether the work is sustainable, whether the person remains in employment, whether their skills and earnings improve, whether they can progress and whether employers are able to retain their staff. Where possible, evaluation should also consider the wider effect on people's confidence, independence and quality of life.

A balanced performance framework should recognise progress towards employment as well as job starts, particularly for people facing substantial barriers. Good measures should support professional judgement and continuous improvement, rather than encourage activity for its own sake.

The opportunity—and the challenge

After two decades working across employability, skills, health and related services, I have seen how fragmented systems can make life harder for the people they are intended to support. The Jobs and Careers Service offers a real opportunity to make that experience more straightforward and more joined up.

But bringing services together on an organisational chart does not automatically create integration for the person using them. Genuine integration happens when information can be shared appropriately, professionals collaborate, employers are engaged, local services work together and people do not have to coordinate every part of their own support.

The service must also recognise that people are not employment cases. They are individuals with ambitions, responsibilities, strengths and challenges. Someone may be seeking a first job, returning after illness, changing career later in life, entering the workplace for the first time or trying to understand how years of caring experience can translate into paid employment. Support needs to start with their circumstances and aspirations.

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Building a service around people and opportunity

The move from Jobcentre Plus and the National Careers Service to the Jobs and Careers Service is an opportunity to build a modern public employment service that combines digital innovation with human expertise; employment support with professional careers guidance; skills with labour-market demand; and national infrastructure with local knowledge.

The technology, data and systems will matter. So will the expertise of the people delivering the service and the contribution of employers, local government, specialist providers and communities. The measure of success will be whether these elements work together to make it easier for people to access the right opportunities and sustain their progress.

If that is achieved, the Jobs and Careers Service could become the foundation of a more connected employment, skills and careers system for England. The goal should not simply be to get people into jobs, but to help them find the right opportunities, build their skills, progress in work and realise their potential.